

Whole wheat lasagna with caramelized onion, dinosaur kale, and basil

I'm from the cook-the-lasagna-noodles-in-the-sauce school. This may seem strange to some, but I like the convenience and the **chewy texture** of the pasta prepared this way. You will need more sauce than usual, as the dry noodles will suck up a lot of liquid. Special no-boil lasagna noodles are also available in some stores. Dinosaur kale is a dark-green, chewy, lemony leaf. It is very tasty and much more tender than regular kale, which can be substituted.

2 large onions, very thinly sliced

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 teaspoon salt

4 garlic cloves, minced

2 tablespoons unrefined cane sugar

1 tablespoon dried basil

1 tablespoon dried oregano

2 teaspoons fennel seeds

1 teaspoon crushed hot red pepper

½ cup port wine [125ml]

1 bunch (about 12 ounces) fresh dinosaur kale, coarsely chopped [350g]

3 cans (28 ounces each) organic tomato sauce [2.25L total]

Freshly ground black pepper

1 pound whole wheat lasagna noodles [500g]

1½ pounds regular or smoked mozzarella, sliced [750g]

½ pound ricotta cheese [250g]

12 ounces Parmesan cheese, shredded [375g]

Simple Béchamel Sauce (recipe follows)

½ cup coarsely chopped fresh basil

1. In a large heavy pot, **sauté** the onions in the olive oil over medium-low heat until soft and very brown, 25 to 35 minutes. Don't rush them; the key to their taste is that they have become tender and sweet, not burned or bitter. Stir the onions every few minutes. Season with ½ teaspoon salt.

2. While the onions are cooking, **mix** the following ingredients in a bowl: the garlic, sugar, basil, oregano, fennel, hot pepper, and remaining ½ teaspoon salt.
3. When the onions are nicely browned, **add** the port and bring to a simmer. With a wooden spoon, scrape off all the caramelized onion bits stuck to the bottom of the pot. Continue to cook, stirring often, until most of the liquid is evaporated.
4. Preheat the oven to 350°F [175°C]. Add the seasoning mixture to the caramelized onions and continue to cook for another 1 to 2 minutes, until the spices are fragrant. Add the kale and stir until the leaves wilt, 1 to 2 minutes. **Pour** in the tomato sauce and bring to a simmer. Season with a generous grinding of black pepper and continue to cook for 15 to 20 minutes.
5. Ladle a light layer of tomato sauce over the bottom of a lasagna pan measuring 9 by 13 inches [23 by 33cm]. **Layer** the noodles across lengthwise and top with more sauce, making sure the noodles are completely covered. Ladle an extra cup [250ml] or so of sauce, more than you normally might because the noodles are uncooked. Reserve ½ of the mozzarella. Add layers of the ricotta, Parmesan, and the remaining mozzarella. Top with more pasta, then cover with béchamel sauce. Add another layer of the cheeses and top with the last layer of pasta. Spoon all but 1½ cups [375ml] of the remaining tomato sauce over all.
6. Cover the pan with aluminum foil and bake for 30 minutes, or until the noodles are cooked all the way through. Test with a sharp paring knife. Raise the oven temperature to 400°F [200°C] and remove the foil. **Top** the lasagna with the remaining sauce and mozzarella and top with the fresh basil. Continue to bake for 10 to 15 minutes, until the top is browned and bubbly. Let rest for 15 to 20 minutes before serving. *Note:* When reheating, use any leftover sauce to moisten the lasagna.

SERVES 8 TO 10

Tip Make the lasagna several hours or a day ahead. Have as much as possible ready to go and prepped before you start cooking—cheese grated and cut, onions sliced, spices set aside in one bowl, tomato cans open, etc.—so you are not caught scrambling in the middle of your preparation. Prepare the béchamel sauce while the tomato sauce is simmering.